

MOBILIZING THE workforce

WAR WORK

▼ Heavy lifting

Female forestry workers loading logs in Finland in 1942. In many countries women played a central role on the home front, providing essential manual labor in farming, agriculture, and forestry.



One of the most enduring images of women's work during World War II (see pp. 234–237) is that of “Rosie the Riveter.” Painted by artist Norman Rockwell, she first appeared in May 1943, on the cover of the US magazine *Saturday Evening Post*. Wearing overalls and goggles, she was depicted with a halo while cradling a riveting machine and trampling a copy of Hitler’s *Mein Kampf* under her feet. “Rosie” represented a positive image of a strong, capable, working woman. Similar poster girls included Canada’s “Ronnie the Bren Gun Girl” (Veronica Foster), who worked on a production line in Toronto, and Ruby Loftus, whose poster was commissioned by the War Artist’s Advisory Committee for her work at



◀ Worn with pride

Thousands of female workers were given lapel badges such as this one to recognize their contribution to the war effort. This silver badge was worn by members of the British Women’s Voluntary Service.

the Royal Ordnance Factory in Newport, England. These valorized images were key to recruiting women into munitions work, which was essential to Allied success, but was tough, dirty, and poorly paid. More than 85,000 US women joined the Women Ordnance Workers, and produced and tested military hardware.

The realities of war work

Millions of women entered the workforce during World War II in Allied nations. More than seven million women in the US were engaged in military production, usually working a 48-hour week with no vacation. On average their salaries were around 50 percent lower than those paid to men. The war also quadrupled the number of African American women working in industry. Women became essential in agricultural production, too. In Britain, the Women’s Land Army was revived in 1939 (having been disbanded after World War I) to increase food production and reduce the country’s reliance on imports. Similar organizations were created in North America, as well as in Australia and New Zealand, where women in this field were nicknamed “farmerettes.”

Elsewhere, the role of women in war work was more limited. In Germany, women were not recruited as heavily into war industry because female participation in the workforce was at odds with Nazi ideology. However,